

THE HOME STRETCH

- 1** IAEA Board of Governors has to ratify an India specific safeguards agreement
- 2** NSG has to make an exception for India to conduct nuclear commerce as a non NPT member state
- 3** The final step will be a US Congress approval on the deal through an up or down vote



negotiations. Subsequently, it gave conditional clearance to the Government to approach the IAEA and to begin negotiations on an India-specific safeguards agreement as part of the Indo-US deal. Under the agreement with the IAEA, India would in phases designate certain reactors as civilian and put them under international safeguards. This would mean that the IAEA would have the right to ensure that any nuclear material used in reactors designated as civilian is properly accounted for and not diverted for military use. The IAEA has slated its Board of Governors meeting for August 1 for approval of the India-specific safeguards agreement. Even before the trust vote, Foreign Secretary Shiv Shankar Menon and senior officials briefed key members of the IAEA board. India is hoping for a consensus when the board meets but Pakistan may insist on a vote. The US

has promised to work on Pakistan to ensure that the passage is smooth.

Even as the IAEA agreement is being stitched up, India, along with the US, has begun a high pitched diplomatic exercise to woo the NSG countries. The NSG countries have to meet to make an exception for India in their rules that ban civilian nuclear trade with countries that are non-signatories to the NPT. Many of the 45 members of the NSG are concerned that by making such an exception for India, the entire NPT structure would be weakened. They may want to put conditions on the waiver that may make it difficult for India to accept. So India is going all out to persuade countries to reach a consensus to permit an exemption for it without any conditions.

Part of the strategy includes sending out Minister for Science and Technology Kapil Sibal,

FRIENDS IN DEED: Manmohan and Bush at the recent G8 summit in Toyako, Japan